

The Game Therapy

This 9/11 novel captures the invisible world of cricket in pre-Obama America

| By Sam Miller |



NETHERLAND
by JOSEPH O'NEILL
Fourth Estate
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 247

N*etherland* is an unassumingly ambitious novel, a beautifully written tale of our times set in New York in the aftermath of 9/11. Joseph O'Neill touches lightly on many great themes—memory, death, violence, poverty, madness, migration, racism and parenthood—but it is his central indulgence, a tender paean to the un-American sport of cricket, that helps make this book so unusual. Cricket also brings together his main characters,

two very unlikely friends: Hans van den Broek, a Dutch investment banker, and Chuck Ramkissoon, a Trinidadian Indian businessman.

The two men could not be more different—van den Broek is introverted and friendless, deserted by his English wife and desperately missing his baby son; while Ramkissoon is a flamboyant, lovable, roguish dreamer with a wife and a mistress, and lots of dodgy business partners. They meet at a cricket match when a drunken spectator pulls a gun on Ramkissoon, whose umpiring decision was less than popular with the bowling team, and

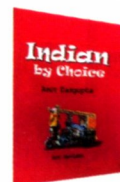
the Dutchman stands, frozen in the batting crease, as the situation is resolved by the Trinidadian. Their paths cross repeatedly, on a ferry, at a taxi driver's restaurant (where van den Broek is accompanied by Vinay, a whisky-loving food critic from Bangalore), and they then travel around the city together, visiting potential and actual cricket grounds.

Netherland is a complex book, written simply—with the confidence and lack of ostentation of a natural writer. O'Neill's withering portrait of van den Broek's lawyer wife, who has become rabidly anti-American, and suffers from what might be termed high self-esteem, is brilliantly drawn. When asked by their marriage counsellor whether she loves her husband, she replies, "Love is such an omnibus word". The platitudes that eventually define a newfound relationship between the couple, partly triggered by a brief holiday in Kerala, may be the only weak point in the book.

Despite several fine passages of that normally-purple literary sub-genre, cricket prose, *Netherland* should not for one moment be mistaken for a sports novel—and sports-haters will enjoy this book as much as anyone else. What O'Neill does, through his characters, is to use cricket as a lens

for looking at American society. He has Ramkissoon say, "Every summer the parks of this city are taken over by hundreds of cricketers but somehow nobody notices. It's like we're invisible. Now that's nothing new, for those of us who are black or brown.... You want a taste of how it feels to be a black man in this country? Put on the white clothes of a cricketer." This declaration has like, much of the rest of the book, a distinctly pre-Obama feel, and the hope that O'Neill evokes about America is ambiguous and evanescent rather than audacious. *Netherland* may well come to be seen as the last, and arguably the best, of the many 9/11 novels, and also, if one wants to be audacious about this, one of the last important works of literature from the pre-Obama period. ■

SAURABH SINGH



INDIAN BY CHOICE
by AMIT DASGUPTA
Wisdom Tree
Price: Rs 995
Pages: 100

This graphic novel captures the journey of self-discovery of a second generation Indian, born and brought up in Chicago.



CENSORSHIP IN INDIA: STUDIES IN FUNDAMENTALISM, OBSCENITY AND LAW
by GIRIJA KUMAR
Har-Anand
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 296

The book deals with the huge challenges that fundamentalism and censorship pose to civilisation in the 21st century.



MAULED BY A TIGER: ENCOUNTERS IN THE INDIAN JUNGLES
by ARTHUR W. STRACHAN
Natraj
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 279
An admirable account of India's forest life. Includes hand-drawings by the author himself.